Circumvention of Internet Censorship

Churui Chen

Henry M. Gunn High School

ENGL 9A

Ms. Katherine Ja

May 1, 2026

Abstract

Government Internet censorship is a massive problem that threatens fundamental human rights. It represents an ever-evolving battle between the government and its people. Ever since the internet was commercialized, the spread of information has increased exponentially. Even though the Internet was designed as an open communications system, national governments have discovered methods to monitor and even block certain information on the Internet. This paper will discuss various ways that nations use to censor information on the internet, arguing that these methods ultimately undermine democratic values and individual autonomy. It will also discuss how citizens all over the world unite in their efforts to devise unique methods to circumvent these blockades.

Keywords: Internet censorship, governmental control, circumvention, global technology policies, human rights

The Birth of the Internet

The internet was developed as an open system to communicate and exchange information and ideas without any restrictions (Leiner, 1997). The original designers intended the Internet to become a medium for collaboration and interaction between individuals without regard for geographic location. However, it has evolved into a space where governments can censor and even monitor information that is being passed around. Despite increasingly sophisticated government censorship systems, people continue to bypass restrictions using evolving technologies, creating a conflict between government control and information freedom.

The Rise of Internet Censorship

The Motive Behind Internet Censorship

Internet censorship has been justified by governments for many reasons, including:

National Security Concerns

The explosive growth of the internet also led to new forms of cyber threats emerging, including DDoS (distributed denial-of-service) attacks, social engineering, and brute force hacking attempts. Large and widely used operating systems such as Microsoft Windows also gained attention from cyber attackers. Well-known hackers, such as Jonathan James, also gained notoriety for hacking into various computer systems, such as those which belonged to the government and NASA. James was the first juvenile incarcerated for cybercrime, after a compromised NASA system was found and traced back to him. Similarly, a group of Russian hackers led by Vladimir Levin was caught creating over 40 illegal transactions via access to the cash management system of a bank. These incidents contributed to growing concerns about cybersecurity and the security (or lack of) of critical digital infrastructure. As cyberattacks became more frequent, governments around the world would begin starting programs to monitor, detect, and prevent online threats. Even though security is a legitimate concern, these programs often serve as a cover for mass surveillance, allowing for the government to look inside the private lives of honest citizens under the veil of protection.

Political Control

Beyond concerns about cybersecurity and national safety, governments also use censorship as a tool for political control. The internet allows citizens to instantaneously send information, communicate with each other, criticize government policies, and organize protests, all actions that are essential to a healthy democracy but are seen as threats by those in power. As social media and online communication grew more prominent, governments used their immense power to censor and limit certain types of information being spread on the Internet. In April 2000, the French government sued Yahoo! after it sold neo-Nazi merchandise. (RCFP, 2006). The lawyers of Yahoo! argued that French jurisdiction did not apply to it, an American company operated nationally. The French court disagreed, and ruled that as long as Yahoo operated in France, it would be subject to French laws. This set a precedent for governments to assert greater control over online content, even if the said website or company mainly operated outside of their borders. As internet usage increased globally, many countries introduced laws that required social media platforms and technology companies to abide by local laws and regulations. Governments argued that measures like these were essential in preventing harmful content from spreading and enforcing the law. Precedents like these grant states the power to define “harmful content”, and often target political dissenters and reporters exercising their free speech.

Spread of Misinformation

One of the main objectives of censorship of the internet is to prevent the spread of misinformation. Because the internet is a medium for the spread of information, anything that someone sends can reach millions of people within a few seconds. In recent years, concerns about misinformation have grown due to the increase of social media and algorithm driven content recommendations. False information regarding political events, medical treatments, and global conflicts has circulated online, often spreading faster than verified information. As a result, governments have now introduced regulations mandating online platforms to remove misleading or harmful content. However, the algorithms used to identify false information cannot ensure complete accuracy. In fact, YouTube's algorithm has mistakenly taken down several pieces of content that were focused on debunking misinformation, flagging them as spreading false information themselves (Tenbarge & Greenspan, 2020).

Methods for Circumventing Internet Censorship

Virtual Private Networks

VPNs, also known as Virtual Private Networks, are one of the most widely used tools for bypassing internet censorship. A VPN works by encrypting an user's data and routing it through a remote server located in a different region or country. This process masks the user's real IP address and information, making it appear as if they are accessing the internet from a different location. Users can use VPNs to access information that would be otherwise blocked in their location. VPNS are most commonly used in regions with rigid internet censorship in order to access social media platforms, news websites, or other communication services that are otherwise restricted. VPNs also prevent user data from being accessed by surveillance and monitoring software.

The Tor Network

The Tor (The Onion Router) network is another widely used network for bypassing internet censorship. Unlike standard browsers, the Tor network protects user anonymity by routing internet traffic through a set of encrypted servers, known as nodes, before reaching its target. These multiple layers of security make it much more difficult to trace the original source of connections. Connecting to the Tor network also gives access to a more private network called sites. Onion sites are websites that can only be accessed through the Tor network. These sites are part of what is called the “dark web”, which is a section of the internet that is not accessible by traditional search engines, and require specialized software to access. Because they are only accessible by special software such as Tor, they are much more secure. However, they are also associated with criminal activity, because the same anonymity that protects them also can be used to host illegal marketplaces, services, and content that operate without any interference by the government.

Conclusion

Even though internet censorship is justified as being a necessary tool for protecting national security, preventing cybercrime, and reducing misinformation, it is a regressive practice that prioritizes the government over individual freedoms. It also negatively impacts how educators spread information by blocking and isolating users from different perspectives. Even when implemented with the intention of improving safety, censorship systems are not always completely accurate, as they sometimes remove legitimate content. Systems of control are inherently prone to error and abuse, as seen with automated moderation moderation, free speech is one of the first casualties of “safety” measures. Access to an unfiltered internet should be viewed as a basic human right in the digital age. Although governments continue to develop increasingly sophisticated censorship technologies, people prove that the human desire for information cannot be permanently oppressed. The false dichotomy between security and freedom must be rejected, and we must create an open internet as its creators intended.

References

References

Akhavan, N. A., Cho, S., Weinberg, Z., Hoang, N. P., Razaghpanah, A., Christin, N., & Gill, P. (2019). *ICLab: A Global, Longitudinal Internet Censorship Measurement Platform*. ArXiv.org. https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.04245

Dal, A., & Nisbet, E. C. (2022). Walking Through Firewalls: Circumventing Censorship of Social Media and Online Content in a Networked Authoritarian Context. *Social Media + Society*, *8*(4), 205630512211377. https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051221137738

Dixon, L., Ristenpart, T., & Shrimpton, T. (2016). *Network Traffic Obfuscation and Automated Internet Censorship*. ArXiv.org. https://arxiv.org/abs/1605.04044

Electronic Privacy Information Center. (n.d.). *Government Use of AI*. EPIC - Electronic Privacy Information Center. https://epic.org/issues/ai/government-use-of-ai/

Greenspan, R. E., & Tenbarge, K. (2020, September 26). *YouTube mistakenly taking down wrong COVID-19 videos debunking misinfo*. Business Insider. https://www.businessinsider.com/youtube-demonetized-covid-19-disinformation-moderation-automation-bots-strikes-2020-9

National Science Foundation. (2025). *Birth of the Commercial Internet*. NSF - National Science Foundation. https://www.nsf.gov/impacts/internet

RCFP. (2006, January 18). *Court throws out Yahoo case over French Web restrictions*. The Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press. https://www.rcfp.org/court-throws-out-yahoo-case-over-french-web-restrictions/

Subramanian, R. (2011). The Growth of Global Internet Censorship and Circumvention: A The Growth of Global Internet Censorship and Circumvention: A Survey Survey. *Communications of the IIMA Communications of the IIMA*, *11*(2), 6. https://scholarworks.lib.csusb.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1164&context=ciima

TOR. (2019). *The Tor Project | Privacy & Freedom Online*. Torproject.org. https://www.torproject.org

Trampski, H. (2024). *Hackers of the '90s*. Purdue.edu. https://cyber.tap.purdue.edu/blog/articles/hackers-of-the-90s/

Vigderman, A., & Turner, G. (2022, June 8). *Internet Censorship in 2021: The Impact of Internet Restrictions*. Security.org. https://www.security.org/vpn/internet-censorship/